

Q What does “expressing” breast milk mean and why should I do it?

Expressing your breast milk involves extracting milk from your breasts without your baby nursing, and it is done for a whole range of reasons.

If your baby is premature or sick and unable to breast-feed, expressing means she can be fed breast milk and get the health benefits. If your breasts are full and uncomfortably engorged in the early weeks, your baby may find it tricky to latch on (see pp.268–69) to a very full breast. Expressing a little milk can reduce the fullness and make latching on easier. If your baby has a weak suck, expressing can help to stimulate your milk supply and keep this at a good level.

Expressing your breast milk also allows you to delegate feeding to someone else. Having a supply of breast milk in the freezer can be handy if you're not feeling well, or need to be away from your baby. If you are returning to work, putting in place an expressing regimen means your baby can continue enjoying your breast milk. If you are still breast-feeding at the time you start your baby on solids, you may want to express milk to mix with her baby rice or purées.

How to express

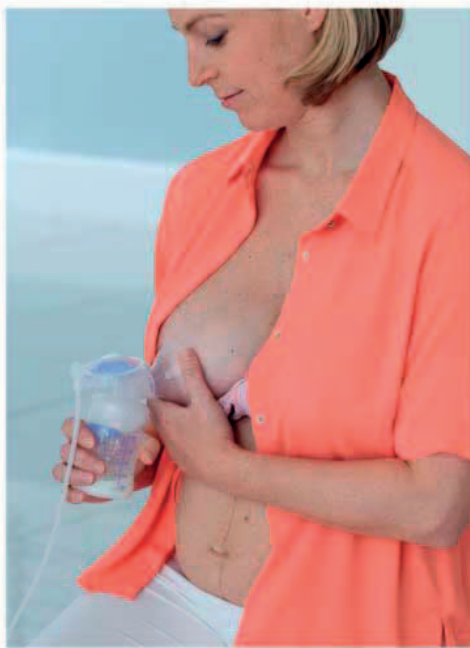
You can express breast milk with your hands or by using a pump. As you get used to expressing, you may combine methods, perhaps using your hands to stimulate the release of milk, and then a pump. Electric pumps are available to rent if you want to express for a short period, for a premature baby for example. Speak a breast-feeding organization or lactation consultant about renting one.

EXPRESSING WITH A BREAST PUMP

Before expressing, make sure that your hands are clean and that all the equipment you use has been washed and sanitized (see p.279).



Expressing with a manual pump This is a bottle with a pump mechanism and a shield that creates a vacuum over your breast. Place the shield over your breast with the nipple area in the middle, then start pumping. Manual pumps are lightweight, but the action of pumping can be tiring.



Expressing with an electric pump An electric motor does the pumping. You can usually adapt the strength of the pump to find a comfortable suction level. These pumps can be more fussy to sanitize than manual ones, but they extract milk more quickly so are a good option if you plan to do a lot of expressing.

HOW TO EXPRESS BY HAND

Have a sterilized container ready to collect your expressed milk. It can take a bit of practice to express your milk by hand, so if you manage to squeeze out only a few drops on the first attempt, try not to give up.



Manipulate the milk Support your breast with one hand and place the other hand above your areola to manipulate the milk toward the nipple.



Squeeze and release Gently squeeze your breast and then release. Repeat this action, gradually building up your speed.



Catch the milk It can take a couple of minutes before milk appears and starts to flow. Catch the expressed milk in a sanitized container. You may need to move the position of your thumb and fingers around your breast to milk all areas.